

Sama Mushtaq

PROGRAM & PROJECT LEADER

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Cross-functional program and operations leader with experience spanning approximately \$30M in cumulative P&L responsibility, teams of up to 120, zero-to-one launches, vendor-led technical delivery, and measurable operating transformations. Brings an operator's accountability to strategy, planning, stakeholder alignment, governance, adoption, and outcome measurement.

CORE CAPABILITIES

Program Strategy | Project Planning | Cross-Functional Leadership | Roadmaps & Dependencies | RAID & Governance | Executive Communication | Vendor Management | Budget & P&L | Change Management | Process Improvement | AI & Data Operations | KPI Design

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Mercor | AI Annotator & Quality Reviewer, Contract | **Feb 2026-Present**

AI QUALITY OPERATIONS

- Evaluate frontier-model outputs across finance, investment, business operations, strategy, business development, engineering, and generalist work.
- Advanced into reviewer responsibilities and was retained for a second priority project based on quality and judgment.

RYGNeco | Co-Founder & Program Lead | **2025-Present**

ZERO-TO-ONE PRODUCT AND VENDOR PROGRAM

- Translated a field e-waste pilot into a four-portal product program covering intake, testing, disposition, data-destruction records, pricing, and client reporting.
- Directed an approximately \$11.5K vendor-built MVP across a co-founder, development vendor, interns, and an AWS architectural adviser.
- Processed 400+ devices in pilot operations, catalogued approximately 480, tested and verified 130, and recorded zero OSHA recordables.

EPIC Brands | General Manager, promoted from AGM | **Jul 2025-Feb 2026**

OPERATING PORTFOLIO AND CONCEPT LAUNCH

- Led a \$10M operating portfolio with 70 hourly employees and six managers, contributing to 20-25% year-over-year growth.
- Built an approximately \$800K events pipeline in six months and reduced controllable costs by 10% through zero-based budgeting.
- Opened Whiskey Yard through SOP development, 30-person hiring and training, and a 150-label whiskey program; bar revenue increased 18%.

Darden Restaurants | Manager-in-Training | **Mar 2025-Jul 2025**

ENTERPRISE LEADERSHIP DEVELOPMENT

- Completed a structured management program in the top 5%, strengthening enterprise operating standards, leadership cadence, and service execution.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE, CONTINUED

Hard Rock Casino Cincinnati | Operations Manager to AGM to Acting GM | **Jan 2024-Jan 2025**

OPERATIONAL TRANSFORMATION

- Held responsibility across three F&B outlets with approximately \$17M in combined P&L and 120 employees, including approximately 80 union team members.
- Recovered approximately \$14K per month in variance, maintained inventory variance below 1%, and reduced labor by 10%.
- Raised alcohol mix from 13% to 22% and upsell rate from 9% to 17% through financial analysis, training, certification, and reinforcement.

iTZCALi Tapas & Tequila | Director of Operations / Launch Consultant | **Sep 2022-Jan 2024**

HIGH-VOLUME LAUNCH PROGRAM

- Coordinated buildout, licensing, menus, vendor relationships, pricing, POS, reservations, staffing, training, payroll, and launch readiness.
- Recruited and trained approximately 60 employees; the concept generated \$165K in its first 14 days and served up to 600 covers nightly.
- Reduced the operating menu from 45 items to 12 and cocktail production from approximately two minutes to 30 seconds.

MAK Trading / Trade with MAK | Founder & Program Lead | **Nov 2019-Present**

DIGITAL COMMUNITY AND GROWTH PROGRAM; MONETIZED 2022-2023

- Built a global education community of approximately 2,000 members, with 1,200+ paid subscribers at peak and approximately \$30K in peak monthly recurring revenue.
- Led brand, acquisition, onboarding, content operations, a 48-page curriculum, member engagement, and a LaunchPass/Stripe to WordPress/MemberPress migration.

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Napoli Italian Eatery | Opening Manager / Operations Lead | 2021-2022

MKEC | Mechanical Design Engineer | 2019-2020

Bella Luna Cafe | GM / Multi-Unit Lead | 2016-2019

SELECTED PROGRAM EVIDENCE

RYGNeco: Field-informed lifecycle, four stakeholder portals, vendor milestones, acceptance criteria, and client reporting architecture.

Hard Rock: Variance controls, beverage capability program, onboarding system, KPI cadence, and frontline adoption.

iTZCALi: Twelve-workstream launch roadmap, menu simplification, bar workflow, pricing, POS, staffing, and training.

MAK Trading: Acquisition, onboarding, curriculum, community cadence, paid access, retention, and platform migration.

EDUCATION AND CREDENTIALS

Wichita State University | Mechanical Engineering studies

University of Wales Trinity Saint David | Business & Management studies

ServSafe Manager | Active through 2029

Languages | English, Arabic, Urdu, Hindi, Punjabi

Portfolio: sama-mushtaq-program-portfolio.samamak.chatgpt.site